Sea water is one of the naturally existing solutions which covers more than 70% of the earth's surface. We cannot imagine life on earth without sea water. It contains many dissolved solids, mostly NaCl. Another important naturally occurring solution is air. Air is a homogeneous mixture of nitrogen, oxygen, carbon dioxide, and other trace gases. Even solid material such as brass is a homogeneous mixture of copper and zinc.

In the above examples the solutions are in different physical states viz... liquid (sea water), gas (air) and solid (alloys), and one common property of all the above is their homogeneity. The homogeneity implies uniform distribution of their constituents or components throughout the mixture. In this chapter, we learn about the solutions and their properties.

9.2 Types of solutions

A solution is a homogeneous mixture of two or more substances, consisting of atoms, ions or molecules. The compound that is present in largest amount in a homogeneous mixture is called the solvent, and others are solutes. For example, when a small amount of NaCl is dissolved in water, a homogeneous solution is obtained. In this solution, Na^+ and Cl^- ions are uniformly distributed in water. Here water is the solvent as the amount of water is more compared to the amount of NaCl present in this solution, and NaCl is the solute.

The commonly used solutions are the solutions in which a solid solute is dissolved in a liquid solvent. However, solute or solvent can be in any of the three states of matter (solid, liquid, gas). If water is used as the solvent,the resultant solution is called as an aqueous solution. If solvents (Benzene, CCl_4, ether etc.,) other than water is used, then the resultant solution is called as a non-aqueous solution.

The following table illustrates the different types of solutions based on the physical state of the solute and solvent.

Table 9.1 Types and examples of solutions

S. No.	State of solution	Solute	Solvent	Examples
1	Gaseous solution	Gas	Gas	Air (A mixture of nitrogen, oxygen and other gases)
		Liquid	Gas	Humid oxygen (Oxygen containing water)
		Solid	Gas	Camphor in nitrogen gas
2	Liquid solutions	Gas	Liquid	CO_2 dissolved in water (carbonated water)
		Liquid	Liquid	Ethanol dissolved in water
		Solid	Liquid	Salt water
3	Solid solutions	Gas	Solid	Solution of H_2 in palladium
		Liquid	Solid	Amalgam of potassium (used for dental filling)
		Solid	Solid	Gold alloy (of copper used in making Jewelery)

9.3 Expressing concentration of solutions

In our life we have come across many solutions of varying strengths or

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